11.2 HTTP Digest Authentication

HTTP digest authentication is superior to the basic authentication as it does not require the client to send an unencrypted password over the network (though HTTP basic authentication is safe over HTTPS). Using digest authentication with Rails is quite easy and only requires using one method, `authenticate_or_request_with_http_digest`.

```
class AdminsController < ApplicationController
  USERS = { "lifo" => "world" }

  before_action :authenticate

  private

    def authenticate
      authenticate_or_request_with_http_digest do |username|
        USERS[username]
      end
    end
end
```

As seen in the example above, the `authenticate_or_request_with_http_digest` block takes only one argument - the username. And the block returns the password. Returning `false` or `nil` from the `authenticate_or_request_with_http_digest` will cause authentication failure.

12 Streaming and File Downloads

Sometimes you may want to send a file to the user instead of rendering an HTML page. All controllers in Rails have the `send_data` and the `send_file` methods, which will both stream data to the client. `send_file` is a convenience method that lets you provide the name of a file on the disk and it will stream the contents of that file for you.

To stream data to the client, use `send_data`:

```
require "prawn"
class ClientsController < ApplicationController
  # Generates a PDF document with information on the client and
  # returns it. The user will get the PDF as a file download.
  def download_pdf
    client = Client.find(params[:id])
    send_data generate_pdf(client),
              filename: "#{client.name}.pdf",
              type: "application/pdf"
  end

  private

    def generate_pdf(client)
      Prawn::Document.new do
        text client.name, align: :center
        text "Address: #{client.address}"
        text "Email: #{client.email}"
      end.render
    end
end
```

The `download_pdf` action in the example above will call a private method which actually generates the PDF document and returns it as a string. This string will then be streamed to the client as a file download and a filename will be suggested to the user. Sometimes when streaming files to the user, you may not want them to download the file. Take images, for example, which can be embedded into HTML pages. To tell the browser a file is not meant to be downloaded, you can set the `:disposition` option to "inline". The opposite and default value for this option is "attachment".